Heart disease

Diagnosis

To diagnose heart disease, a healthcare professional examines you and listens to your heart. You are usually asked questions about your symptoms and your personal and family medical history.

Tests

Many different tests are used to diagnose heart disease.

- **Blood tests.** Certain heart proteins slowly leak into the blood after heart damage from a heart attack. Blood tests can be done to check for these proteins. A high-sensitivity C-reactive protein (CRP) test checks for a protein linked to inflammation of the arteries. Other blood tests may be done to check cholesterol and blood sugar levels.
- **Chest X-ray.** A chest X-ray shows the condition of the lungs. It can show if the heart is enlarged.

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- **Electrocardiogram (ECG or EKG).** An ECG is a quick and painless test that records the electrical signals in the heart. It can tell if the heart is beating too fast or too slow.
- **Holter monitoring.** A Holter monitor is a portable ECG device that's worn for a day or more to record the heart's activity during daily activities. This test can detect irregular heartbeats that aren't found during a regular ECG exam.
- **Echocardiogram.** This noninvasive exam uses sound waves to create detailed images of the heart in motion. It shows how blood moves through the heart and heart valves. An echocardiogram can help determine if a valve is narrowed or leaking.
- **Exercise tests or stress tests.** These tests often involve walking on a treadmill or riding a stationary bike while the heart is checked. Exercise tests help reveal how the heart responds to physical activity and whether heart disease symptoms occur during exercise. If you can't exercise, you might be given medicine that affects the heart like exercise does.
- **Cardiac catheterization.** This test can show blockages in the heart arteries. A long, thin flexible tube called a catheter is inserted in a blood vessel, usually in the groin or wrist, and guided to the heart. Dye flows through the catheter to arteries in the heart. The dye helps the arteries show up more clearly on X-ray images taken during the test.
- **Heart CT scan, also called cardiac CT scan.** In a cardiac CT scan, you lie on a table inside a doughnut-shaped machine. An X-ray tube inside the machine rotates around your body and collects images of your heart and chest.
- **Heart magnetic resonance imaging (MRI) scan.** A cardiac MRI uses a magnetic field and computer-generated radio waves to create detailed images of the heart.

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Treatment

Heart disease treatment depends on the cause and type of heart damage. Treatment for heart disease may include:

- Lifestyle changes such as eating a diet low in salt and saturated fat, getting more exercise, and not smoking.
- Medicines.
- A heart procedure.
- Heart surgery.

Medications

You may need medicines to control heart disease symptoms and prevent complications. The type of medicine used depends on the type of heart disease.

Surgery or other procedures

Some people with heart disease may need a heart procedure or surgery. The type of treatment depends on the type of heart disease and how much damage has happened to the heart.

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Lifestyle and home remedies

Lifestyle changes are an important part of heart disease treatment and prevention. The following changes are recommended to improve heart health:

- **Don't smoke.** Smoking is a major risk factor for heart disease. If you smoke and can't quit, talk with your healthcare team about programs or treatment

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that can help.

- **Eat healthy foods.** Eat plenty of fruits, vegetables and whole grains. Limit sugar, salt and saturated fats.
- **Control blood pressure.** Uncontrolled high blood pressure increases the risk of serious health conditions. Get your blood pressure checked at least every two years if you're 18 or older. If you have risk factors for heart disease or are over age 40, you may need more-frequent checks. Ask your healthcare professional what blood pressure reading is best for you.
- **Get a cholesterol test.** Get a cholesterol test when you're in your 20s and then at least every 4 to 6 years. You may need to start testing earlier if high cholesterol is in your family history. You may need cholesterol checks more often if your test results aren't in a desirable range or you have risk factors for heart disease.
- **Manage diabetes.** If you have diabetes, controlling your blood sugar can help reduce the risk of heart disease.
- **Exercise.** Staying active keeps the heart healthy. Exercise at least 30 minutes a day on most days of the week. Talk with your healthcare team about the amount and type of exercise that's best for you.
- **Keep a healthy weight.** Being overweight increases the risk of heart disease. Ask your healthcare professional what weight is best for you.
- **Manage stress.** Find ways to help reduce emotional stress. Some tips are to get more exercise, practice mindfulness and connect with others in support groups.
- **Practice good hygiene.** Regularly wash your hands and brush and floss your teeth to keep yourself healthy.
- **Get good sleep.** Poor sleep may increase the risk of heart disease and other long-term health conditions. Adults should try to get 7 to 9 hours of sleep daily. Kids often need more. Go to bed and wake at the same time every day,

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including on weekends. If you have trouble sleeping, talk with your healthcare professional about strategies that might help.

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Coping and support

Here are some ways to help manage heart disease and improve quality of life:

- **Cardiac rehabilitation.** This is a personalized program of education and exercise. It includes exercise training, emotional support and education about a heart-healthy lifestyle. The supervised program is often recommended after a heart attack or heart surgery.
- **Support groups.** Connecting with friends and family or joining a support group is a good way to reduce stress. You may find that talking about your concerns with others in similar situations can help.
- **Get regular health checkups.** Seeing your healthcare professional regularly helps make sure you're properly managing your heart disease.

Preparing for your appointment

Some types of heart disease are found at birth or during an emergency, for example, when someone has a heart attack. You may not have time to prepare

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If you think you have heart disease or are at risk of heart disease because of family history, see your healthcare professional. You may be referred to a doctor trained in heart diseases. This type of doctor is called a cardiologist.

Here's some information to help you prepare for your appointment.

What you can do

- **Be aware of pre-appointment restrictions.** When you make the appointment, ask if there's anything you need to do in advance, such as restrict your diet. For example, you may be told not to eat or drink for a few hours before a cholesterol test.
- **Write down symptoms you're having,** including any that seem unrelated to heart disease.
- **Write down important personal information**. Note if you have a family history of heart disease, stroke, high blood pressure or diabetes. Also write down any major stresses or recent life changes.
- **Make a list of medicines,** vitamins or supplements you're taking. Include the dosages.
- **Take someone along,** if possible. Someone who goes with you can help you remember information you're given.
- **Be prepared to talk about** your diet and any smoking and exercise habits. If you don't already follow a diet or exercise routine, ask your healthcare team how to get started.
- **Write down questions to ask** your healthcare professional.

For heart disease, some basic questions to ask your healthcare professional include:

- What is the likely cause of my symptoms or condition?
- What are other possible causes?

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- What tests do I need?
- What's the best treatment?
- What are the options to the treatment that you're suggesting?
- What foods should I eat or avoid?
- What's an appropriate level of physical activity?
- How often should I be screened for heart disease? For example, how often do I need a cholesterol test?
- I have other health conditions. How do I manage them together?
- Are there restrictions that I need to follow?
- Should I see a specialist?
- Are there brochures or other materials that I can have? What websites do you recommend?

Don't hesitate to ask other questions.

What to expect from your doctor

Your healthcare team is likely to ask you many questions, such as:

- When did your symptoms begin?
- Do you always have symptoms or do they come and go?
- On a scale of 1 to 10 with 10 being the worst, how bad are your symptoms?
- What, if anything, seems to improve your symptoms?
- What, if anything, makes your symptoms worse?
- Do you have a family history of heart disease, diabetes, high blood pressure or other serious illness?

What you can do in the meantime

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It's never too early to make healthy-lifestyle changes. Eat a healthy diet, get more exercise and don't smoke. A healthy lifestyle is the best protection against heart disease and its complications.

By Mayo Clinic Staff

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